

STAGE TEN • RELATIONSHIPS & CONNECTIONS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 30 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Ten • Relationships & Connections

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Ten, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Ten covers thirty FIRSTS across three sections: Friendships & Peer Connections, Project Partners & Teamwork, and Mentorship & Professional Connections. Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt.

This stage is more personally revealing than most — it asks participants to reflect honestly on real friendships, real conflicts, and real professional relationships. Expect more emotional variance in the room than in more skills-based stages, and give genuine space for that rather than rushing through it.

SESSION 1

Friendships & Peer Connections

Covers *FIRSTS N1-N10*

FIRST N1

Genuine Friendship Formed

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one relationship they will deliberately invest in beyond mere proximity or circumstance.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine friendships, distinct from casual acquaintances, provide real emotional support and often become some of the most durable relationships across a career and life.
- Proximity (a roommate, a classmate) is a starting point, not the same thing as genuine friendship — it takes deliberate investment to become one.
- This is the foundation for the entire section; everything from N2 through N10 assumes at least one relationship worth genuinely building.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Confusing proximity with genuine friendship, without ever actually investing beyond circumstance.
- Assuming friendship happens automatically over time without any deliberate action.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N2

Peer Support Exchange

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants offer and request one specific, concrete form of support within a real friendship this week.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Friendships that only run one direction — always giving or always receiving — tend to feel unbalanced over time.
- Genuine reciprocal support, not just goodwill, sustains a relationship's real health.
- Specificity matters: a vague offer to help is easy to make and rarely actually taken up.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Offering vague, low-commitment help (“let me know if you need anything”) that's easy to say but rarely acted on.
- Only ever being on the receiving end of support without offering anything back.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N3

Fun/Relaxation Activity with Friends

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants plan and follow through on one genuine, non-transactional social activity with friends.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Relationships and personal wellbeing both suffer when every interaction becomes purely transactional or achievement-focused.
- Deliberate fun is part of a genuinely sustainable life, not a distraction from real priorities.
- Social time is often the first thing cut when busy — name that pattern explicitly before asking people to resist it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating social time as the first thing to cut when busy, rather than a protected part of a sustainable routine.
- Feeling guilty for time spent purely on connection rather than productivity.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N4

Conflict Resolution with a Friend

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one unaddressed tension in a real friendship and plan a respectful, direct conversation to address it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Friendships that avoid all conflict often become shallow or eventually rupture over unaddressed tension.
- Genuine friendships can withstand, and even deepen through, respectful disagreement.
- Avoidance often damages a friendship more than the discomfort of a direct, respectful conversation would.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding conflict indefinitely out of fear of damaging the friendship.
- Assuming any disagreement signals the friendship is fundamentally broken.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N5

Appreciation Note to a Friend

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write and send one specific, genuine appreciation note to a real friend.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine appreciation, stated explicitly, strengthens relationships and reinforces the specific behaviors that made the friendship valuable.
- Specificity is what separates a genuine note from an empty gesture — name the actual thing the friend did.
- This is a small, low-cost action with disproportionately real relational value.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sending a vague, generic thank-you that doesn't reflect genuine, specific reflection.
- Assuming a friend already knows they're appreciated without ever actually saying so.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N6

Reflection on Friendship Qualities

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify the specific qualities that make their strongest friendships genuinely work.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without deliberate reflection, it's easy to drift into friendships based on convenience rather than genuine compatibility.
- Not all friendships share the same qualities — examining what specifically makes the best ones work is genuinely useful, not obvious.
- This sets up N7 through N10 by clarifying what participants are actually trying to build more of.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming all friendships share the same underlying qualities without ever actually examining them.
- Confusing longevity of a friendship with its genuine quality.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N7

Networking through Friendships

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants make one genuine, specific introduction connecting a friend to someone in their own network.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuinely helping friends access your professional network, not just using your network for yourself, builds real goodwill.
- A vague introduction (“you two should meet!”) doesn't give either party a real reason to engage — specificity is what makes it work.
- This reframes networking as something reciprocal, not purely self-serving.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Making a vague, low-context introduction that doesn't give either party a genuine reason to engage.
 - Only using personal networks for one's own benefit, never for a friend's.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N8

Collaborative Study Session

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants organize one genuinely structured study session with a peer that produces real academic progress.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Studying collaboratively, done well, often produces deeper understanding than solo study alone.
- This also strengthens a genuine peer relationship, not just academic outcomes.
- Structure is what prevents the session from drifting into purely social time.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting an unstructured study session drift into purely social time without genuine progress.
 - Assuming collaborative study is inherently less rigorous than studying alone.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N9

Trust-Building Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants share something genuinely vulnerable with a friend whose trust has already been earned.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Trust deepens specifically through genuine vulnerability, not just shared activities.
- Friendships that never move past surface-level topics often plateau rather than deepen.
- Timing and fit matter — vulnerability shared before trust is earned can feel mismatched for both people.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sharing vulnerability with someone who hasn't yet earned that trust, which can feel mismatched or uncomfortable.
 - Assuming vulnerability means oversharing indiscriminately rather than genuine, appropriately-timed openness.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N10

Group Celebration or Milestone Recognition

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants organize or contribute to one genuine celebration marking a real group milestone.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Celebrating milestones together, not just individually, strengthens group bonds and creates shared positive memories.
- Milestones often pass unacknowledged simply because no one takes the initiative — this closes the section by making that initiative explicit.
- This doesn't need to be elaborate; genuine intentionality matters more than scale.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting genuine milestones pass unacknowledged because no one takes initiative to organize anything.
- Assuming celebration only counts if it's elaborate or expensive.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 2

Project Partners & Teamwork

Covers *FIRSTS N11-N20*

FIRST N11

Project Partner Identified

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliberately select a project partner based on genuine complementary fit, not just convenience.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The right project partner meaningfully affects both the quality of the work and the actual experience of doing it.
- Deliberate selection beats defaulting to the most familiar or comfortable choice.
- This is the foundation for the entire section — everything through N20 assumes a genuinely well-chosen partnership or team.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Defaulting to the most familiar or comfortable choice rather than genuinely evaluating fit for the specific project.
 - Choosing a partner solely based on friendship rather than genuine complementary skill.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N12

Task Delegation Practice

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants openly discuss and fairly divide tasks with a real project partner or team.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Fair, clear delegation prevents both resentment from uneven workload and confusion about who owns what.
- These are two of the most common sources of real project team friction, and both are avoidable.
- Discussing delegation openly, not letting it happen implicitly, is the actual fix.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting delegation happen implicitly and unevenly rather than discussing it openly from the start.
 - Assuming tasks will naturally sort themselves out without explicit conversation.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N13

Team Goal Alignment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants explicitly confirm that every team member shares the same understanding of the project's actual goal.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Teams that assume alignment without confirming it often discover mid-project they were working toward subtly different goals.
- This is a costly, entirely avoidable problem — a single explicit conversation prevents it.
- A shared assignment brief doesn't guarantee shared interpretation of that brief.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming alignment based on a shared brief, without confirming everyone interprets it the same way.
- Treating a kickoff meeting as sufficient alignment without ever revisiting it as the project evolves.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST N14

Collaborative Problem-Solving Session

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants work through a real shared problem with a partner, ensuring both perspectives are genuinely heard before converging on a solution.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Problems tackled collaboratively often surface better solutions than either person would reach alone.
- This only works when the session is genuinely structured to draw out both perspectives, not just the more vocal one.
- Hearing the other's reasoning first, before proposing your own solution, changes the quality of the outcome.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting one partner's solution dominate without genuinely hearing the other's reasoning first.
- Treating disagreement about the solution as a sign the partnership isn't working.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST N15

Peer Feedback Exchange

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants exchange real, specific feedback with a partner at a genuine mid-project checkpoint, not just at the end.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Ongoing feedback within a partnership catches issues early and builds a genuinely stronger final result.
- Waiting until the very end of a project makes issues much harder to fix.
- This should be built into the workflow, not treated as an optional extra step.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Waiting until the very end of a project to exchange any feedback.
- Avoiding real feedback mid-project out of concern it will feel awkward or critical.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N16

Accountability Partner Agreement

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants create a specific, mutual accountability agreement with a real partner, including concrete check-in frequency.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A formal, mutual agreement, not just a vague intention, is what actually makes accountability partnerships work consistently.
- “We’ll keep each other accountable” means nothing without specifics: how often, in what format, checking what.
- This directly extends N12’s delegation practice into an ongoing, sustained structure.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Agreeing to “keep each other accountable” vaguely, without specifying what that actually means.
- Setting up an agreement once and never revisiting whether it’s actually being followed.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N17

Group Reflection & Debrief

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants hold a genuine group debrief after a shared project experience, surfacing insights that individual reflection alone would miss.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Individual reflection alone misses insights that only surface when a team discusses a shared experience together.
- A genuine group debrief captures collective learning, not just each person’s private takeaways.
- This is worth scheduling deliberately, not skipped in the rush to the next task.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping the group debrief in favor of only individual reflection.

- Treating a debrief as just a status update rather than genuine collective reflection.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N18

Conflict Mediation in a Team

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants address a real, unresolved team conflict directly and collaboratively rather than letting it continue unaddressed.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Team conflicts, left unaddressed, tend to fester and affect the whole team's output.
- Resolving them collaboratively, rather than avoiding them, protects both the project and the relationships involved.
- Letting a conflict simmer usually makes the eventual necessary conversation harder, not easier.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting the conflict simmer unaddressed, hoping it resolves itself.
- Assuming team conflict is inherently destructive rather than something that can be navigated constructively.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N19

Recognition of Team Contributions

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants pause to genuinely acknowledge specific team contributions before moving to the next task.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Teams that never pause to genuinely recognize collective effort tend to feel less cohesive and motivated.
- Moving straight to the next task without acknowledgment is a common, easily fixed oversight.
- Genuine, specific recognition matters more than generic praise.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Moving straight to the next task without pausing to genuinely acknowledge what the team accomplished.
- Offering only generic praise ("great job team") rather than specific recognition.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N20

Leadership or Facilitation Role in a Group

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliberately take on a leadership or facilitation role in a group setting, rather than defaulting to a contributor position.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Deliberately taking on a leadership role builds skills essential for career advancement and team effectiveness alike.
- Defaulting to a comfortable contributor role indefinitely means missing that growth entirely.
- This closes the section by turning everything from N11 through N19 into practiced, active leadership.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Continuing to default to a comfortable contributor role indefinitely, avoiding the discomfort of leading.
- Assuming leadership requires a formal title rather than genuine initiative within a group.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 3

Mentorship & Professional Connections

Covers *FIRSTS N21-N30*

FIRST N21

Mentor Identified

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify a specific potential mentor based on genuine relevant experience and real willingness to invest, not prestige.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The right mentor relationship can meaningfully accelerate growth, but only with deliberate identification of genuine fit.
- Prestige or title alone doesn't guarantee a mentor will actually invest time or attention.
- This is the foundation for the entire section — N22 through N24 all assume a genuinely well-chosen mentor.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Choosing a mentor based purely on prestige or title, without considering genuine fit or willingness to invest.
- Assuming a formal title (“mentor”) is required before a relationship can begin developing.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N22

Mentor Meeting Scheduled

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants send a specific, low-friction meeting request to a real potential mentor.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Identifying a potential mentor without ever actually scheduling time means the relationship never gets a chance to develop.
- A vague, open-ended request makes it easy for a busy person to postpone indefinitely.
- Specificity (a proposed time, a clear ask) genuinely increases the odds of a real meeting happening.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sending a vague, open-ended request that makes it easy to postpone indefinitely.
- Waiting for the mentor to initiate contact rather than taking the first step.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N23

Thoughtful Question to a Mentor

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare specific, genuinely tailored questions for a real mentor conversation.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A mentor conversation's value depends heavily on the quality of the questions asked.
- Thoughtful, specific questions produce far more useful guidance than generic ones that could apply to anyone.
- This directly determines how valuable N22's scheduled meeting actually turns out to be.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking generic questions that could apply to anyone, rather than ones tailored to a specific situation.
- Preparing so many questions that the conversation feels like an interrogation rather than a dialogue.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST N24

Follow-Up with Mentor

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants send a genuine follow-up after a mentor conversation, sustaining the relationship beyond a single meeting.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Mentor relationships, like any professional relationship, fade without deliberate follow-up.
- Genuine follow-up is what turns a single conversation into an ongoing relationship.
- This closes the mentor-specific arc (N21–N24), setting up the broader professional network focus in N25–N29.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating a single mentor conversation as the whole relationship, without any follow-up.
- Sending a generic thank-you rather than genuine follow-up connected to what was actually discussed.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST N25

Peer Networking Circle Formed

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants form a small peer circle with genuine structure for mutual accountability, not just casual social contact.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A small peer circle provides broader perspective and support than a single accountability partner.
- It maintains genuine intimacy and mutual investment while still offering breadth beyond a single relationship.
- Structure is what prevents the circle from drifting into purely social meetings without real substance.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Forming the circle without any real structure, letting meetings drift into purely social time.
- Assuming a larger group automatically provides more value than a smaller, more intentional one.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST N26

Industry Contact Made

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants make one genuine industry contact through authentic engagement, not purely transactional outreach.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Industry contacts provide insight, opportunities, and credibility that are difficult to gain any other way.
- Deliberately building these connections compounds significantly over an entire career.
- Treating the interaction as purely transactional undermines the genuine relationship-building this FIRST is about.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating the interaction as purely transactional, focused only on what you can get from the contact.
- Making contact once and never following up to sustain the relationship.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N27

Coffee Chat with a Professional

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants conduct one genuine, relaxed coffee chat with a professional, rather than treating it as a rigid formal interview.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Coffee chats, done well, build genuine relationships more effectively than formal informational interviews.
- The lower-stakes, relaxed format specifically encourages more authentic conversation.
- Treating it like a rigid interview undercuts the actual advantage of this format.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating a coffee chat like a rigid, formal interview, which undercuts the relaxed format's advantage.
 - Over-preparing a scripted list of questions rather than allowing genuine, natural conversation.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N28

Volunteer Collaboration

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants collaborate with others through a genuine volunteer or shared-purpose activity.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Volunteering alongside others builds genuine relationships through shared purpose.
- This often produces more authentic connections than purely networking-focused interactions.
- The relationship-building value comes specifically from the shared purpose, not from treating it as a networking event.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating volunteer work as purely transactional networking, missing the genuine relationship-building it enables.
 - Choosing a cause purely for how it looks on a resume rather than genuine shared purpose.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N29

Peer Recommendation Given

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants give one genuine, specific recommendation for a real peer's actual work.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Giving genuine recommendations, not just seeking them, is what makes a professional network mutually beneficial.
- A generic, low-effort recommendation doesn't reflect specific, genuine knowledge of someone's actual work.
- This reframes networking, once again, as reciprocal rather than purely self-serving — echoing N7 from Section 1.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Giving a generic, low-effort recommendation that doesn't reflect specific, genuine knowledge.
 - Only ever seeking recommendations for oneself without ever offering one to someone else.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST N30

Reflection on Relationship Growth

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants honestly review their relationship-building practice across this entire stage, naming genuine strengths and remaining gaps.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Looking across a whole relationship-building practice reveals genuine growth patterns that no single relationship alone would show.
- Honest reflection here should cover friendships, teamwork, and mentorship — all three sections of this stage, not just one.
- This closes the entire stage; frame it as a genuine, ongoing practice rather than a completed checklist.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reviewing only the relationship-building areas that feel comfortable, avoiding honest assessment of harder ones.
- Treating this reflection as a final grade rather than an ongoing, evolving practice.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*